

Tax Debt & IRS Relief

Owe the IRS and can't pay? You have real, official options — payment plans, settling for less, and hardship relief. Below are the legitimate national resources. Tick the box once you've checked each one.

⚠ BEFORE YOU START

The IRS would rather work with you than chase you — but you must respond to notices. Watch out for “tax relief” companies on TV that charge huge fees for things you can do yourself for free or cheap.

1 Set Up a Payment Plan

The IRS lets most people pay over time, often online in minutes.

☐ IRS Online Payment Plan

Apply online to pay your balance over months or years. Most people qualify.

→ www.irs.gov/payments/online-payment-agreement-application

☐ Short-Term Extension

Need just a little time? You can request up to 180 extra days to pay.

→ www.irs.gov/payments

2 Settle for Less Than You Owe

If you truly can't pay, the IRS may accept a reduced amount.

☐ Offer in Compromise

Settle your tax debt for less than the full amount if you qualify. Use the free pre-qualifier tool first.

→ www.irs.gov/payments/offer-in-compromise

☐ Currently Not Collectible

If paying would leave you unable to cover basics, the IRS may pause collection.

→ www.irs.gov/businesses/small-businesses-self-employed/temporarily-delay-the-collection-process

3 Get Free Expert Help

Free, independent help when you're stuck with the IRS.

☐ Taxpayer Advocate Service

A free, independent IRS office that helps when you have a hardship or can't resolve an issue.

→ www.taxpayeradvocate.irs.gov 1-877-777-4778

☐ Low Income Taxpayer Clinic (LITC)

Free legal help for disputes with the IRS if you're low-income. See the Free Legal Help to Fight the IRS guide.

→ www.taxpayeradvocate.irs.gov/litc

4 Reduce Penalties

You may be able to remove penalties you've been charged.

☐ Penalty Relief / First-Time Abatement

If you usually file on time, the IRS may remove penalties. Just ask.

→ www.irs.gov/payments/penalty-relief

⚠ WATCH OUT FOR

Ignore TV and radio ads promising to "settle your IRS debt for pennies" for a big upfront fee — most people don't qualify for that, and you can apply yourself for free. A real Offer in Compromise is filed directly with the IRS.

★ A TIP THAT HELPS

Always open and respond to IRS letters — ignoring them leads to liens, levies, and garnished wages. Even a phone call to set up a small payment plan stops most collection actions.

NEED HELP WHERE YOU LIVE?

Need help where you live?

This guide covers national options. For a local low-income tax clinic or help with your specific situation, use the personalized AI search or ask in the Questions area, and we'll point you to free help.

MY NOTES — WHO I CALLED, WHEN, AND WHAT THEY SAID
